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(54) **SLIDABLE FREE-ROTATING BARBELL
GRIP**

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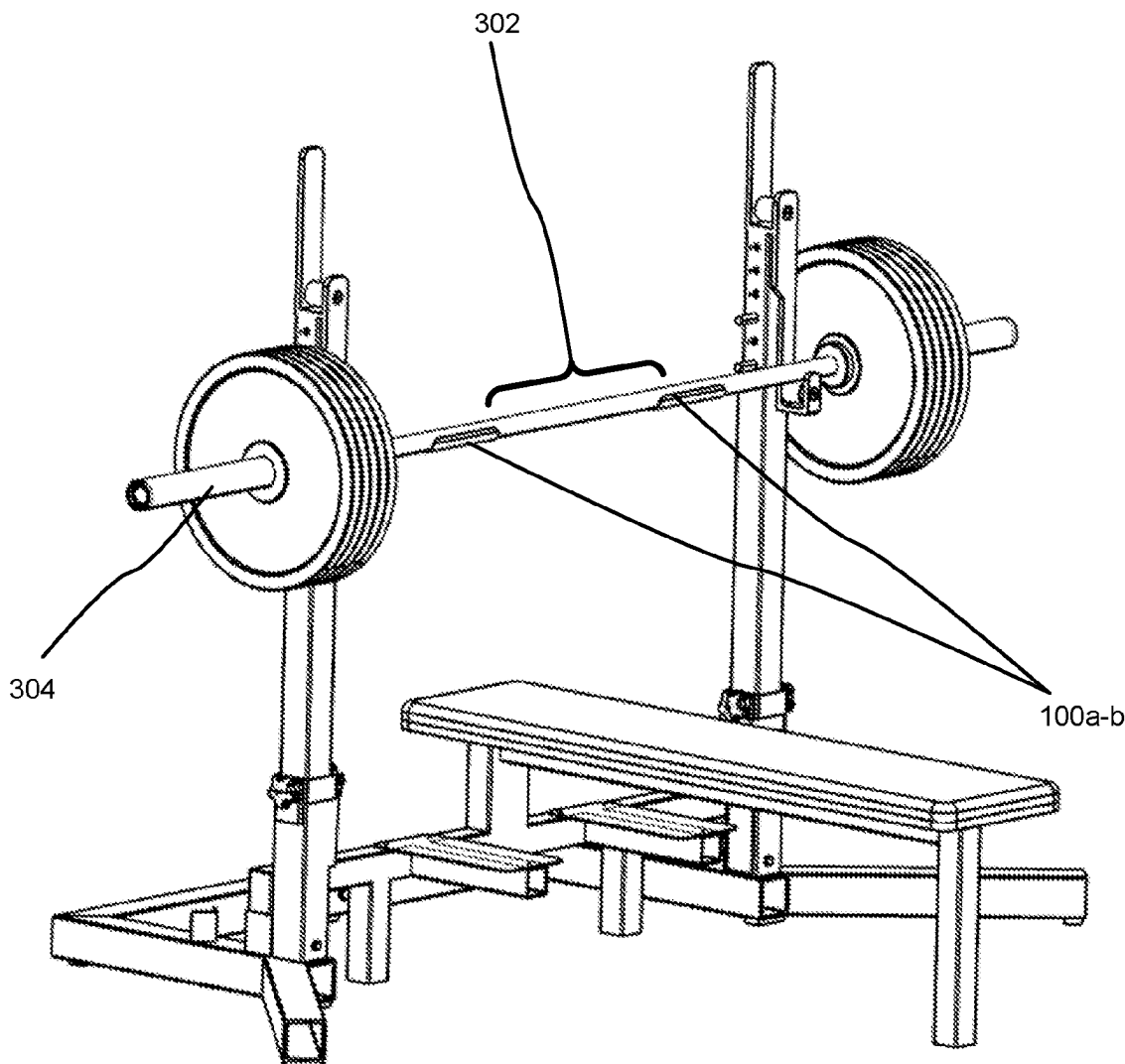
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(57) **ABSTRACT**

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A rigid or semi-rigid grip adapted to slide and/or rotate freely on a barbell, operable to allow a user to activate stabilizer muscles and tendons and providing a free range of motion across during select weightlifting exercises, such as bench press, contributing to core strength training and core strength development.

300



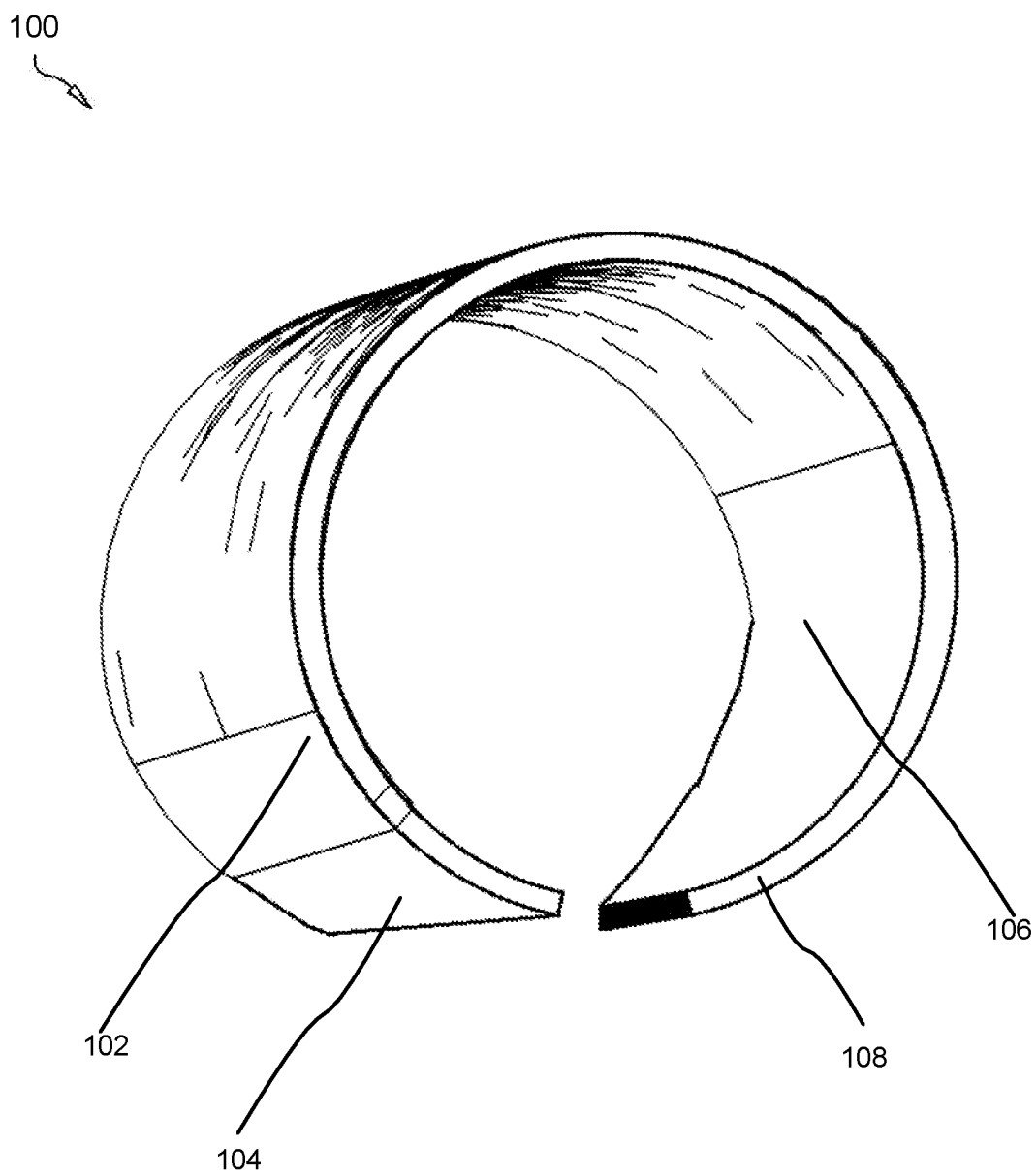


FIG. 1

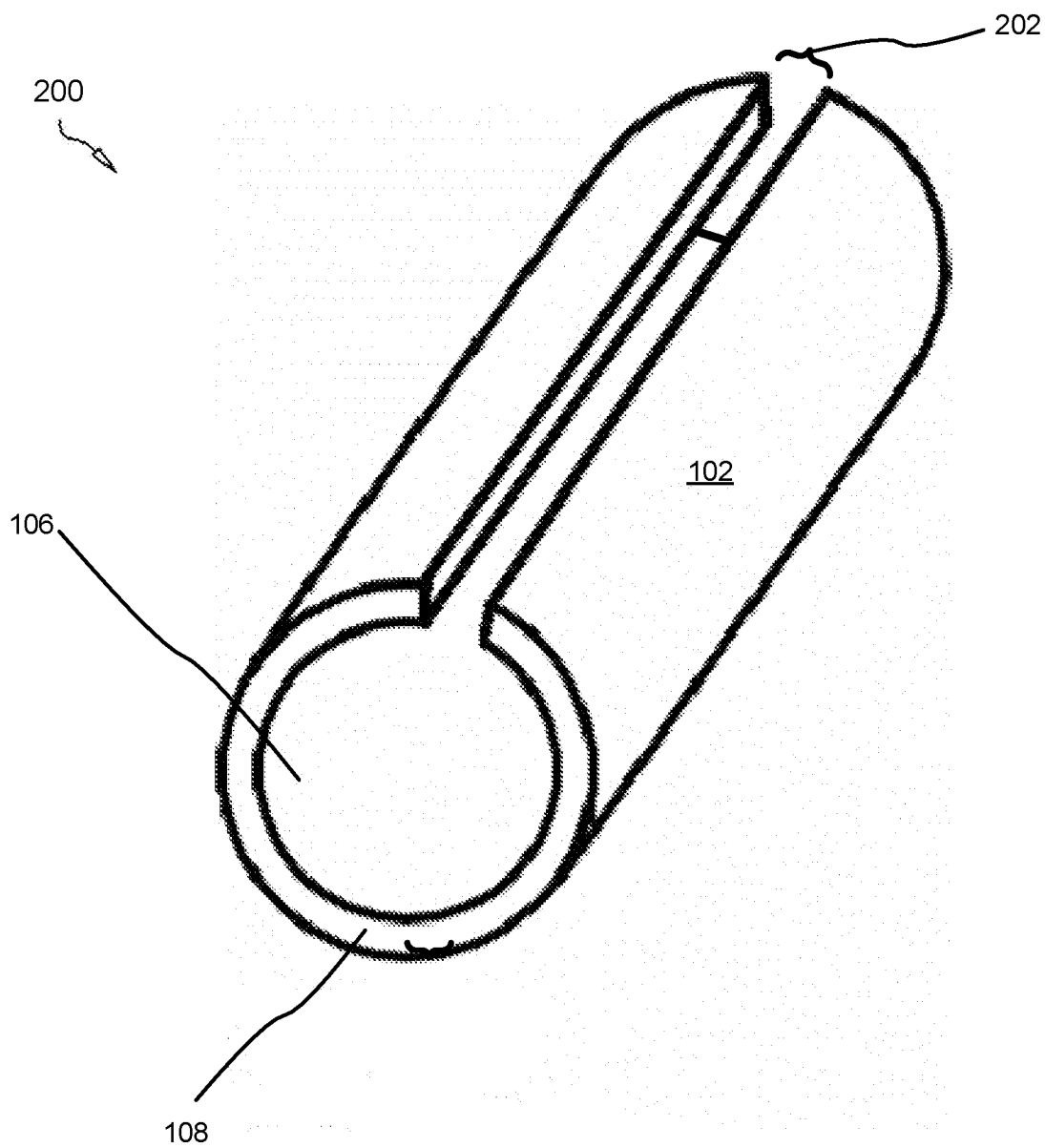


FIG. 2

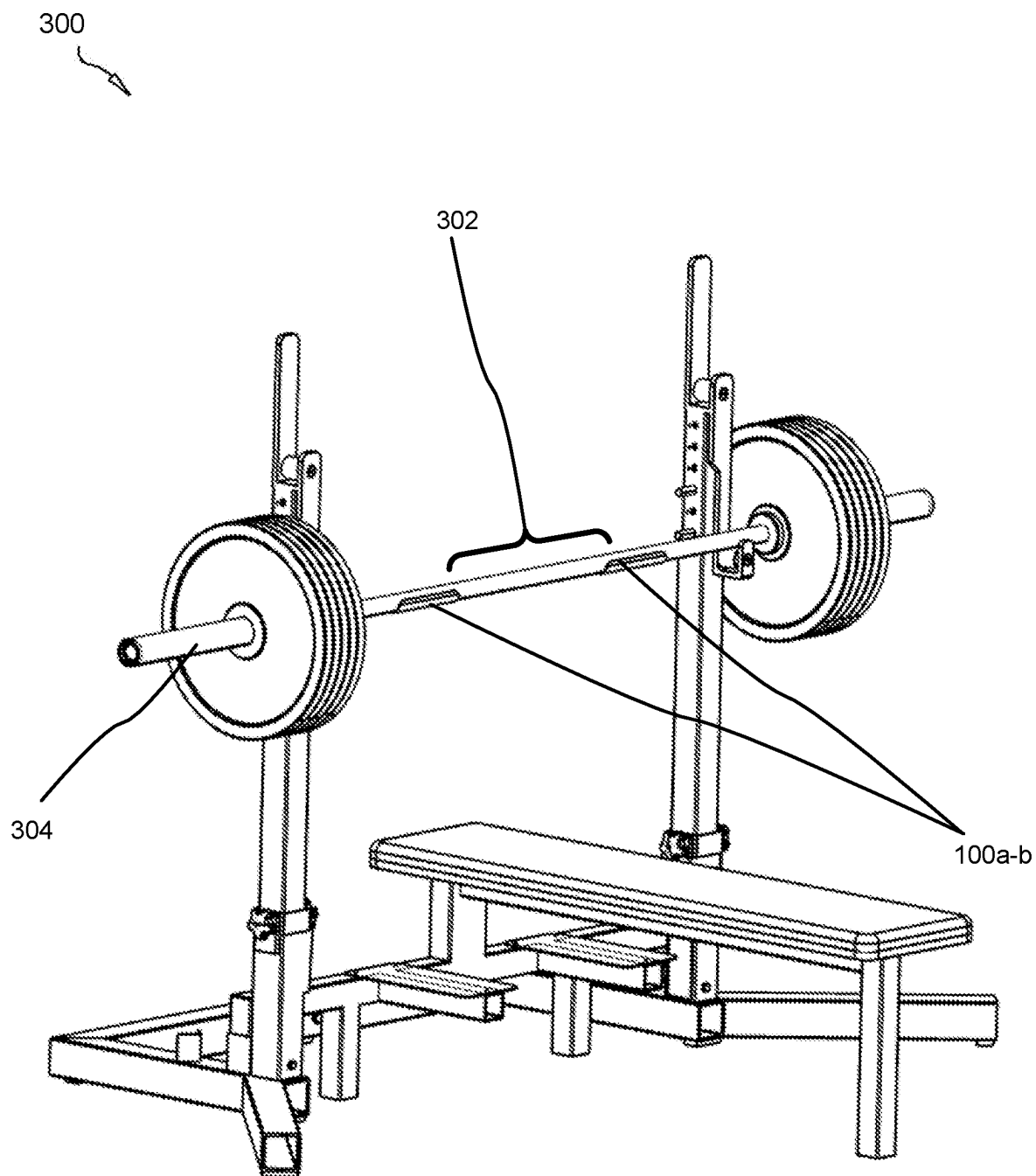


FIG. 3

400

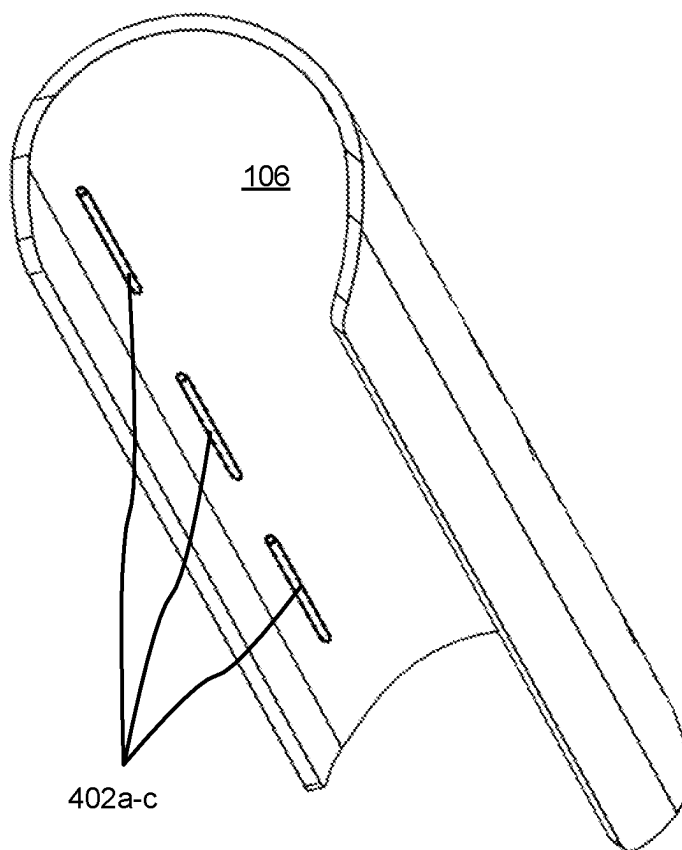


FIG. 4

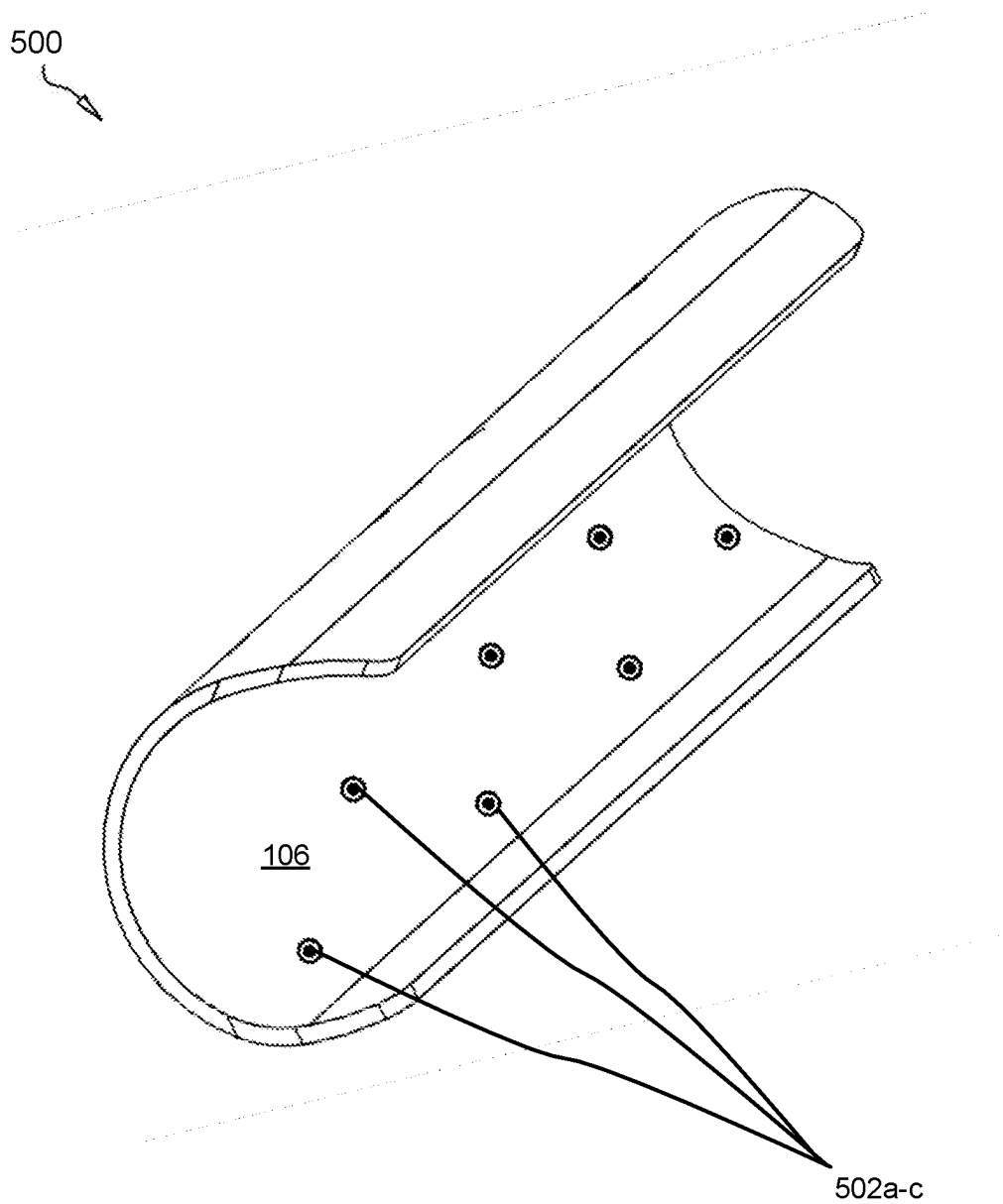


FIG. 5

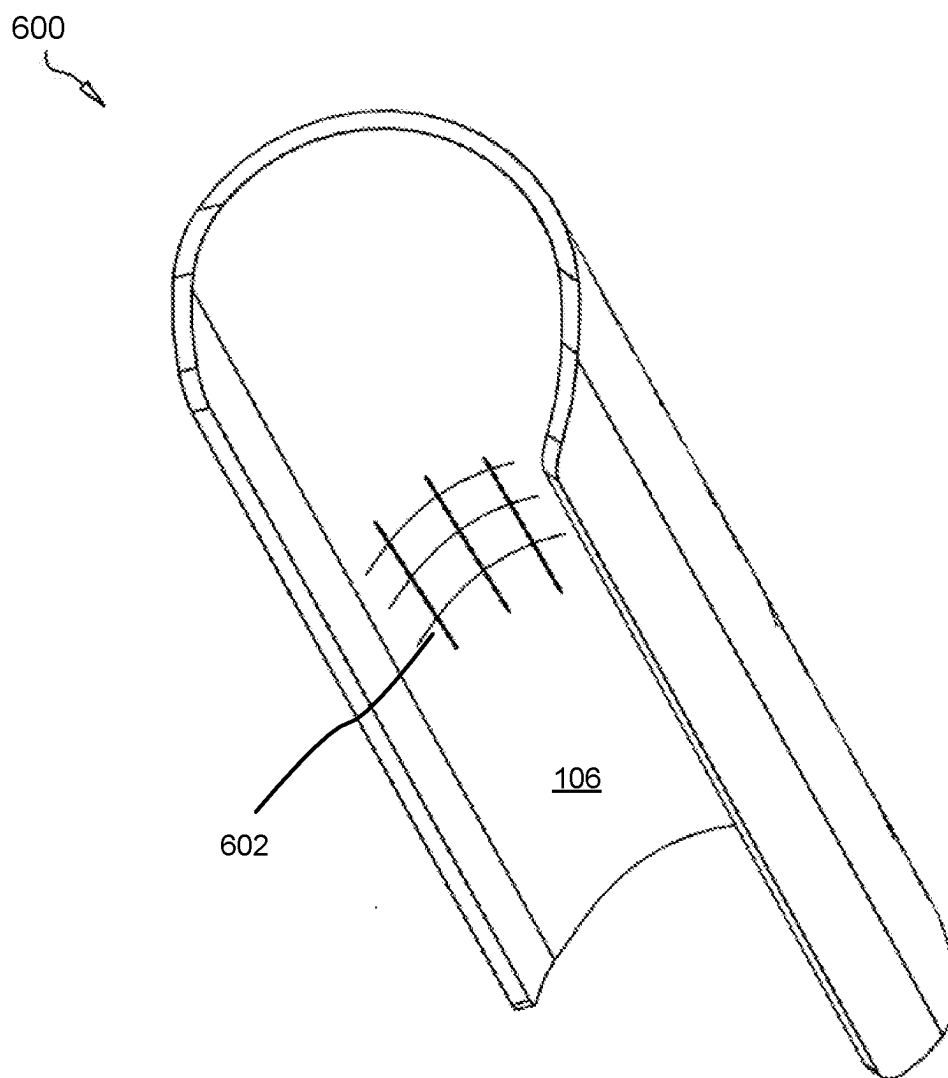


FIG. 6

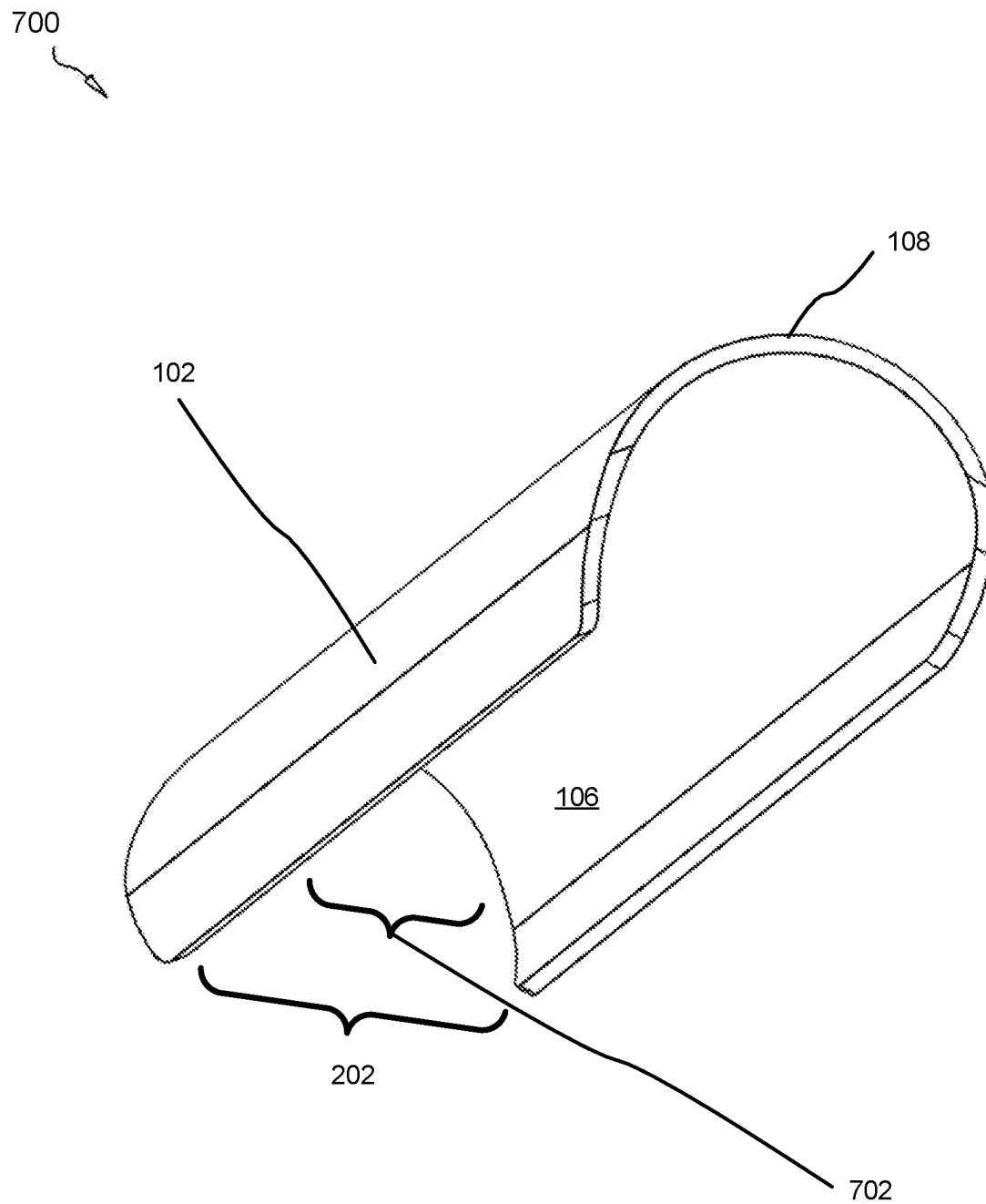


FIG. 7

SLIDABLE FREE-ROTATING BARBELL GRIP

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

[0001] This invention relates to exercise equipment; and more particularly relates to grips for barbells.

BACKGROUND

Description of the Related Art

[0002] General fitness is an increasingly popular goal of modern populations. An aspect of general fitness is weight-lifting in which barbells are used in lifts such as the bench press. In performing a bench press, shoulder press, curls, and other exercises, the palms are traditionally positioned statically on the barbell as the weights are moved. Although most exercises, including bench press, do not completely isolate any particular muscle group, such as the pectoral or triceps, the static positioning of the hands does prevent stabilizer muscles and tendons from being activated which would traditionally be necessary to stabilize a weight through a free range of motion. Additionally, the static positioning of the hands strains the wrists as the forearms move axially during lifts such as the bench press.

[0003] There exists no efficient methods, systems or apparatus in the art which allow for free range of motion of the hands while performing exercises using dumbbells and barbells. There is a need in the art for a simple and efficient means of converting a static grip on a barbell to free-moving grip.

SUMMARY

[0004] From the foregoing discussion, it should be apparent that a need exists for a free-moving barbell grip. The present invention has been developed in response to the present state of the art, and in particular, in response to the problems and needs in the art that have not yet been fully solved by currently available nesting solutions. Accordingly, the present invention has been developed to provide a free-rotating, detachable grip for a barbell, the grip comprising: an interrupted, semi-rigid sleeve dimensioned to have an interior circumference exceeding an exterior circumference of a barbell; wherein the sleeve comprises an exterior surface, a forward surface, and an interior surface, the sleeve defining a hollow interior recess adapted to receive a barbell; wherein the sleeve defines a slit operable to allow the grip to detachably affix over a barbell.

[0005] The grip may comprise polymeric materials. The interior surface may comprise texturing. The interior surface may comprise a plurality of rollers. The interior surface may comprise a plurality of ball bearings in some embodiments.

[0006] The grip may be operable to slide laterally on a barbell when grip pressure is released. The grip may be operable to slide axially on a barbell when grip pressure is released.

[0007] A second free-rotating, detachable grip for a barbell is provided, the grip comprising: an interrupted, semi-rigid sleeve dimensioned to have an interior circumference exceeding an exterior circumference of a barbell; wherein the sleeve comprises an exterior surface, a forward surface, and an interior surface, the sleeve defining a hollow interior recess adapted to receive a barbell; wherein the sleeve defines a slit operable to allow the grip to detachably affix

over a barbell; wherein the grip is operable to slide laterally and axially on a barbell when grip pressure is released; wherein the grip is operable to lock in place forming a friction fit with the barbell when grip pressure is increased.

[0008] Reference throughout this specification to features, advantages, or similar language does not imply that all of the features and advantages that may be realized with the present invention should be or are in any single embodiment of the invention. Rather, language referring to the features and advantages is understood to mean that a specific feature, advantage, or characteristic described in connection with an embodiment is included in at least one embodiment of the present invention. Thus, discussion of the features and advantages, and similar language, throughout this specification may, but do not necessarily, refer to the same embodiment.

[0009] Furthermore, the described features, advantages, and characteristics of the invention may be combined in any suitable manner in one or more embodiments. One skilled in the relevant art will recognize that the invention may be practiced without one or more of the specific features or advantages of a particular embodiment. In other instances, additional features and advantages may be recognized in certain embodiments that may not be present in all embodiments of the invention.

[0010] These features and advantages of the present invention will become more fully apparent from the following description and appended claims, or may be learned by the practice of the invention as set forth hereinafter.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0011] In order that the advantages of the invention will be readily understood, a more particular description of the invention briefly described above will be rendered by reference to specific embodiments that are illustrated in the appended drawings. Understanding that these drawings depict only typical embodiments of the invention and are not therefore to be considered to be limiting of its scope, the invention will be described and explained with additional specificity and detail through the use of the accompanying drawings, in which:

[0012] FIG. 1 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0013] FIG. 2 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0014] FIG. 3 illustrates an environmental perspective of free-rotating grips according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0015] FIG. 4 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0016] FIG. 5 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0017] FIG. 6 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0018] FIG. 7 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention; and

[0019] FIG. 8 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip and pry bar according to an embodiment of the present invention.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0020] Reference throughout this specification to “one embodiment,” “an embodiment,” or similar language means that a particular feature, structure, or characteristic described in connection with the embodiment is included in at least one embodiment of the present invention. Thus, appearances of the phrases “in one embodiment,” “in an embodiment,” and similar language throughout this specification may, but do not necessarily, all refer to the same embodiment.

[0021] Furthermore, the described features, structures, or characteristics of the invention may be combined in any suitable manner in one or more embodiments. In the following description, numerous specific details are provided, such as examples of programming, software modules, user selections, network transactions, database queries, database structures, hardware modules, hardware circuits, hardware chips, etc., to provide a thorough understanding of embodiments of the invention. One skilled in the relevant art will recognize, however, that the invention may be practiced without one or more of the specific details, or with other methods, components, materials, and so forth. In other instances, well-known structures, materials, or operations are not shown or described in detail to avoid obscuring aspects of the invention.

[0022] The phrases “at least one,” “one or more,” and “and/or” are open-ended expressions that are both conjunctive and disjunctive in operation. For example, each of the expressions “at least one of A, B and C,” “at least one of A, B, or C,” “one or more of A, B, and C,” “one or more of A, B, or C” and “A, B, and/or C” means A alone, B alone, C alone, A and B together, A and C together, B and C together, or A, B and C together.

[0023] The term “a” or “an” entity refers to one or more of that entity. As such, the terms “a” (or “an”), “one or more” and “at least one” can be used interchangeably herein. It is also to be noted that the terms “comprising,” “including,” and “having” can be used interchangeably.

[0024] FIG. 1 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip 100 according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0025] The grip 100 comprises a rigid or semi-rigid interrupted sleeve 102. The grip 100 is tubular and dimensioned to slide on a barbell. The grip comprises an exterior surface 104, an inner surface 106, and a forward surface 108 which may be equivalent to a thickness of the sleeve 102. The thickness may vary from 0.1 mm thick to 10 mm thick.

[0026] The sleeve 102 may be manufactured from polymeric materials, metal, metal alloys, carbon fiber, or organic materials such as wood or leather. The sleeve 102 is adapted to flex and/or compress slightly when a gripping force is applied to the sleeve 102.

[0027] In various embodiments, the sleeve 102 comprises a flexible, polymeric sock. On other embodiments, the sleeve 102 comprises tubing such as PVC piping. The flexibility of the grip may be adapted to allow a user to slip the grip 100 onto the barbell with an amount of force equal to or less than the force an average user may apply his hands.

[0028] The grip 100 may vary from 4-10 inches in length, or 5-8 inches in some embodiments, and 1-2 inches in diameter in still further embodiments.

[0029] FIG. 2 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip 200 according to an embodiment of the present invention;

[0030] The sleeve 102 does not form an uninterrupted fit around the circumference of the barbell, but rather is interrupted by a recess 202 (i.e., slit 202) which serves the mutual function of providing means to snap the grip 200 onto the barbell and allowing the sleeve 202 to compress in diameter when gripped firmly. The recess 202 may vary from 0.1 mm in width to 50 mm.

[0031] FIG. 3 illustrates an environmental perspective of free-rotating grips 100a-b according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0032] The grips 100a-b are positioned on a barbell 304. In various embodiments, the grips are spaced apart from one another by a predetermined distance 302. The distance 302 may change during the bench press exercise as the grips 100a-b slide laterally to and fro on the barbell 304. The grips 100a-b may also rotate axially on the barbell 304. A user may increase the grip force applied to the grips 100a-b to force the grips 100a-b into contact with the barbell 304, creating a friction fit between the grips 100a-b and the barbell 304, increasing the friction between them 304, 100a-b.

[0033] FIG. 4 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip 400 according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0034] In various embodiments, the interior surface 106 is affixed to one or more rollers 402a-b are operable to allow permit axial rotation of the grip 400 about the barbell while increasing resistant to lateral movement of the grip 400 on the barbell. This embodiment may be used for wrist-strengthening exercises. The rollers 402a-b are non-spherical bearings operable to roll in one direction.

[0035] FIG. 5 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip 500 according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0036] In the shown embodiment, the interior surface 106 comprises a plurality of ball bearings 502a-c operable to decrease friction between the grip 500 and the barbell 304, forcing a user to exercise more control and activate more stabilizing muscles to control the barbell 304.

[0037] FIG. 6 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip 600 according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0038] In some embodiments of the present invention, the interior surface 106 is textured with a repeating or non-repeating pattern 602 to increase friction between the sleeve 600 and the barbell 304. The texturing 602 may comprise engraved and/or relief texturing. The texturing 602 may also be affixed, or incorporated into, the exterior surface 104 to increase friction with the hands of a user.

[0039] FIG. 7 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0040] In various embodiments, the recess 202 spans 1% to 179% of the circumferences of the sleeve 700. The recess 202, in some embodiments, may span 3% to 125% of the circumference of the sleeve 700.

[0041] The sleeve 700 defines a hollow interior recess 702 adapted to receive the barbell 304. The sleeve 700 detachably affixes, or snaps in some embodiments, over the barbell 304.

[0042] FIG. 8 illustrates a forward perspective of a free-rotating grip and pry bar assembly 800 according to an embodiment of the present invention.

[0043] The grip assembly 800 includes a pry bar 802. The pry bar 802 may comprise an elongated, oblong, ovoid, or rectangular implement adapted for handheld use. The pry bar 802 may comprise polymeric or metal alloy materials and is operable to pry up a corner of the grip 700 releases said grip 700 from a barbell.

[0044] In various embodiments, the sleeve/grip body 102 is bifurcated into two halves 804a-b along at a seam 806, which may be along a top surface. The two halves 804a-b may be hingedly affixed. The body 102 may clamp down on the barbell 304 and be held in place using clamps, buckles, or other means known to those of skill in the art.

[0045] The present invention may be embodied in other specific forms without departing from its spirit or essential characteristics. The described embodiments are to be considered in all respects only as illustrative and not restrictive. The scope of the invention is, therefore, indicated by the appended claims rather than by the foregoing description. All changes which come within the meaning and range of equivalency of the claims are to be embraced within their scope.

What is claimed is:

1. A free-rotating, detachable grip for a barbell, the grip comprising:

an interrupted, semi-rigid sleeve dimensioned to have an interior circumference exceeding an exterior circumference of a barbell;

wherein the sleeve comprises an exterior surface, a forward surface, and an interior surface, the sleeve defining a hollow interior recess adapted to receive a barbell;

wherein the sleeve defines a slit operable to allow the grip to detachably affix over a barbell.

2. The grip of claim 1, wherein the grip comprises polymeric materials.

3. The grip of claim 1, wherein the interior surface comprises texturing.

4. The grip of claim 1, wherein the interior surface comprises a plurality of rollers.

5. The grip of claim 1, wherein the interior surface comprises a plurality of ball bearings.

6. The grip of claim 1, wherein the grip is operable to slide laterally on a barbell when grip pressure is released.

7. The grip of claim 1, wherein the grip is operable to slide axially on a barbell when grip pressure is released.

8. A free-rotating, detachable grip for a barbell, the grip comprising:

an interrupted, semi-rigid sleeve dimensioned to have an interior circumference exceeding an exterior circumference of a barbell;

wherein the sleeve comprises an exterior surface, a forward surface, and an interior surface, the sleeve defining a hollow interior recess adapted to receive a barbell;

wherein the sleeve defines a slit operable to allow the grip to detachably affix over a barbell;

wherein the grip is operable to slide laterally and axially on a barbell when grip pressure is released;

wherein the grip is operable to lock in place forming a friction fit with the barbell when grip pressure is increased.

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